



HEALTH PROFESSIONS ADVISING

PHYSICIAN ASSISTANT HANDBOOK

Purpose of This Handbook

Preparing for PA school requires strong academic preparation, substantial direct patient care experience, an informed understanding of the profession, and careful attention to the requirements of individual PA programs.

This handbook was developed by Villanova University's Health Professions Advising (HPA) Program to help you navigate each stage of the journey to PA school. Whether you are just beginning to explore the profession or preparing to submit your CASPA application, this resource is designed to provide practical guidance and evidence-based advising that reflects current admissions practices and nationally recognized standards.

Throughout this handbook, you will find information on:

- Exploring the physician assistant profession
- Preparing academically for PA school
- Gaining meaningful patient care, healthcare, leadership, service, and research experiences
- Understanding the competencies and qualities valued by PA programs
- Planning for the GRE, PA-CAT, Casper, and other admissions assessments, when required
- Navigating the CASPA application process
- Selecting programs, preparing for interviews, and understanding gap years and academic enhancement options
- Accessing Villanova and national advising resources

While this handbook is comprehensive, it is not intended to serve as a checklist or guarantee admission. Every PA program has its own mission, prerequisite requirements, admissions priorities, and expectations for applicants. Your experiences, interests, and goals are unique, and your preparation should reflect those individual circumstances.

Use this handbook alongside individual PA program admissions websites and regular meetings with HPA. Because program requirements vary considerably, HPA can help you interpret admissions requirements, evaluate your preparation, and develop an application strategy that reflects your individual goals and timeline.

Connect with Health Professions Advising

Schedule an Appointment in Handshake

Whether you're exploring the physician assistant profession for the first time or preparing to apply, Health Professions Advising is here to support you.

We encourage students to schedule an appointment early and visit us often throughout their undergraduate journey.

Meet with HPA to discuss:

- PA school prerequisites and how they fit within your academic plan
- Exploring the physician assistant profession and assessing career fit
- Clinical, shadowing, service, leadership, and research experiences
- GRE, PA-CAT, Casper, and other admissions assessments, when applicable
- Application strategy, school selection, and the CASPA application
- Personal statements, letters of recommendation, and interviews
- Gap years and academic enhancement pathways



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Navigating this Handbook

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Exploring the Physician Assistant Profession

What is a Physician Assistant?

Physician assistants (PAs) are licensed healthcare professionals who diagnose and treat illnesses, develop treatment plans, prescribe medications, assist in surgery, and provide preventive care as part of a collaborative healthcare team. Working in partnership with physicians and other healthcare professionals, PAs help improve access to high-quality, patient-centered care across a wide variety of medical and surgical specialties.

The PA profession was established in the 1960s to address growing healthcare needs and physician shortages. Since then, it has evolved into one of the fastest-growing healthcare professions in the United States. PAs are educated through rigorous graduate-level programs that combine classroom instruction with extensive clinical training, preparing them to practice medicine in diverse healthcare settings.

One of the defining features of the PA profession is its flexibility. PAs are educated as medical generalists and can work in virtually every area of medicine, including family medicine, emergency medicine, surgery, pediatrics, internal medicine, cardiology, dermatology, oncology, psychiatry, orthopedics, and many other specialties. Unlike physicians, PAs are not required to complete a residency before entering practice (although postgraduate PA residency and fellowship programs are available in some specialties), allowing many graduates to begin caring for patients shortly after completing their education and obtaining licensure.

PAs practice in a variety of settings, including hospitals, physician offices, community health centers, urgent care clinics, surgical practices, academic medical centers, correctional facilities, military healthcare systems, and rural or medically underserved communities. Their responsibilities vary depending on their specialty and practice setting but often include conducting physical examinations, ordering and interpreting diagnostic tests, developing treatment plans, counseling patients, performing procedures, assisting in surgery, and collaborating with physicians and other members of the healthcare team.

Is the Physician Assistant Profession Right for You?

Becoming a physician assistant requires much more than strong grades and healthcare experience. It requires a genuine commitment to caring for others, working collaboratively within healthcare teams, and serving patients with compassion, professionalism, and integrity. Before committing to the PA pathway, take time to reflect on your interests, values, strengths, and long-term career goals.

Successful PAs enjoy building meaningful relationships with patients while working in a fast-paced, team-based healthcare environment. They are lifelong learners who are comfortable

making clinical decisions, communicating with patients and colleagues, adapting to new situations, and balancing both autonomy and collaboration in patient care.

As you explore the profession, consider questions such as:

- Do you enjoy working directly with patients during times of illness, injury, and recovery?
- Are you interested in diagnosing and treating a wide range of medical conditions?
- Do you enjoy working as part of an interdisciplinary healthcare team?
- Are you comfortable with lifelong learning and adapting to advances in medicine?
- Does the flexibility to practice in different medical specialties appeal to you?
- Are you motivated by service, empathy, and improving the health and well-being of others?

One of the best ways to determine whether the PA profession is a good fit is through firsthand experience. Shadowing physician assistants, working in direct patient care roles, volunteering in healthcare settings, and speaking with practicing PAs can provide valuable insight into the realities of the profession. These experiences not only strengthen your understanding of the career but also help you determine whether the responsibilities, pace, and collaborative nature of PA practice align with your personal and professional goals.

Explore the profession carefully before applying so that you can make an informed decision and clearly explain why the PA role fits your interests and career goals.

What Does a Typical Career Look Like?

The journey to becoming a physician assistant begins with completing a bachelor's degree and the prerequisite coursework required by PA programs. Successful applicants also gain substantial direct patient care experience, healthcare experience, shadowing, and service before applying. After earning a graduate degree from an accredited PA program, graduates must pass the Physician Assistant National Certifying Examination (PANCE) and obtain state licensure before entering clinical practice.

Unlike physicians, PAs are educated as medical generalists and are not required to complete residency training before beginning practice. Most graduates enter the workforce immediately after graduation and certification, although optional postgraduate PA residency and fellowship programs are available in specialties such as emergency medicine, surgery, critical care, psychiatry, oncology, orthopedics, and dermatology for those seeking additional advanced training.

One of the defining features of the PA profession is the ability to change specialties throughout a career. While additional on-the-job training is often required, PAs are not typically required to complete a new formal educational program when transitioning from one specialty to another. This flexibility allows many PAs to adapt their careers as their interests evolve or as healthcare needs change.

Throughout their careers, PAs maintain certification through continuing medical education (CME) and periodic certification requirements established by the National Commission on Certification of Physician Assistants (NCCPA). Lifelong learning is an essential part of the profession and helps ensure that PAs continue to provide safe, evidence-based care.

Many PAs spend their careers in direct clinical practice, while others pursue leadership, education, research, healthcare administration, public health, military service, or specialty practice. Regardless of the setting, PAs play an important role in delivering high-quality, collaborative healthcare and improving access to care for patients and communities.

Practice Areas for Physician Assistants

Unlike physicians, who complete residency training in a specific specialty after medical school, physician assistants are educated as medical generalists. This broad medical education allows PAs to practice in nearly every area of medicine. While many PAs spend years developing expertise within a specialty, the profession offers the flexibility to transition between specialties throughout a career as interests, opportunities, and healthcare needs evolve.

Below are examples of common practice areas for physician assistants.

Practice Area	Description
Family Medicine	Provides comprehensive primary care for patients of all ages, including preventive care, chronic disease management, and acute illnesses.
Internal Medicine	Diagnoses and manages complex medical conditions affecting adult patients in outpatient and inpatient settings.
Emergency Medicine	Evaluates and treats patients with acute illnesses, injuries, and medical emergencies in fast-paced emergency departments.
General Surgery	Assists in surgical procedures while providing preoperative, intraoperative, and postoperative patient care.
Orthopedic Surgery	Cares for patients with musculoskeletal injuries and conditions, assists in surgery, and manages fractures, joint disorders, and sports injuries.
Pediatrics	Provides preventive, acute, and chronic medical care for infants, children, and adolescents.

Cardiology	Evaluates and manages patients with heart and vascular diseases in both inpatient and outpatient settings.
Dermatology	Diagnoses and treats skin, hair, and nail disorders while performing procedures such as biopsies and lesion removal.
Psychiatry	Assesses, diagnoses, and helps manage mental health conditions alongside psychiatrists and behavioral health teams.
Obstetrics & Gynecology	Provides reproductive healthcare, prenatal and postpartum care, and women's preventive health services.
Critical Care	Cares for critically ill patients in intensive care units, managing complex medical conditions and procedures.
Oncology/Hematology	Evaluates and manages patients with cancer and blood disorders, often working alongside multidisciplinary care teams.
Urgent Care	Treats non-life-threatening illnesses and injuries requiring same-day medical attention.
Hospital Medicine	Provides inpatient care for hospitalized patients, coordinating treatment plans and collaborating with specialists.

Exploring the Profession Before Applying

Before applying to PA school, develop a realistic understanding of the profession through direct patient care experience, PA shadowing, and conversations with practicing PAs. These experiences can help you understand the responsibilities and day-to-day realities of PA practice and determine whether the profession is a good fit for you.

Shadowing Physician Assistants

Shadowing provides an opportunity to observe how PAs care for patients, collaborate with physicians and other healthcare professionals, communicate with patients and families, and navigate the realities of clinical practice. Many PA programs recommend or require applicants to shadow one or more practicing PAs before applying.

As you shadow, pay attention not only to the medical care being provided, but also to the PA's role within the healthcare team. Observe how the PA communicates with patients, works alongside physicians, nurses, and other healthcare professionals, balances autonomy with collaboration, and adapts to the unique demands of their specialty.

Gain Direct Patient Care Experience

One of the defining characteristics of PA admissions is the expectation that applicants have significant hands-on patient care experience before matriculating. Patient care expectations vary widely by program. Some programs require a specific minimum number of hours, while others evaluate the type, duration, and level of responsibility involved in an applicant's experience.

Examples of direct patient care experience may include working as an emergency medical technician (EMT), paramedic, certified nursing assistant (CNA), patient care technician (PCT), medical assistant (MA), respiratory therapist, athletic trainer, physical therapist assistant, registered nurse, or in another role that involves direct responsibility for patient care. While every PA program defines qualifying patient care experience differently, the goal is the same: to develop the clinical skills, professionalism, communication, and confidence needed to succeed in PA school and clinical practice.

Engage Beyond Clinical Experience

In addition to patient care and shadowing, seek opportunities to become involved in activities that support your personal and professional development. Volunteering in your community, participating in pre-PA student organizations, conducting informational interviews with practicing PAs, engaging in research, or taking on leadership roles can broaden your understanding of healthcare and demonstrate qualities that admissions committees value.

These experiences help you develop teamwork, communication, leadership, cultural humility, and service while exposing you to the diverse patient populations and healthcare settings in which PAs practice.

Reflect on Your Experiences

The goal of career exploration is to understand the PA role and determine whether it is a good fit for you. Applicants should be prepared to explain what they learned from their experiences and why they want to become a PA.

As you gain experience, ask yourself:

- What aspects of the PA profession appeal to me most?
- What challenges did I observe, and how did the PA and healthcare team respond?
- How did my patient care experiences influence my understanding of healthcare?
- Why does the PA profession fit my interests, strengths, and long-term goals better than other healthcare careers?
- How have these experiences shaped my motivation to pursue a career as a physician assistant?

Reflecting on these experiences will help you determine whether the PA profession is right for you and explain your motivation more clearly in your application and interviews.

Academic Preparation

Choosing a Major

One of the most common misconceptions about PA school admissions is that students must major in biology or another science discipline. In reality, there is no preferred or required undergraduate major for most PA programs. Students from a wide variety of academic backgrounds are admitted each year, provided they complete the prerequisite coursework and demonstrate strong academic performance.

When choosing a major, consider your interests, strengths, and long-term goals. Selecting a field of study that genuinely interests you can increase your engagement in the classroom, support your academic success, and provide opportunities to develop unique perspectives and experiences that strengthen your application. Whether you major in biology, psychology, public health, business, engineering, communication, or another discipline, your primary goal should be to excel academically while completing the prerequisites required by your intended PA programs.

Unlike many undergraduate degree requirements, prerequisite coursework for PA programs is not standardized. While most programs require foundational courses in biology, chemistry, anatomy and physiology, microbiology, and statistics, additional requirements such as genetics, biochemistry, medical terminology, nutrition, psychology, or developmental psychology vary by institution. Some programs also require that prerequisite courses be completed within a certain number of years prior to matriculation.

Because prerequisite requirements differ significantly among programs, research prospective PA programs early. Your Faculty Advisor can help you make decisions about your major, degree requirements, course selection, and sequencing, while HPA can help you interpret PA program prerequisites and admissions requirements.

PA School Prerequisites

Unlike many other health professions, prerequisite requirements for PA programs can vary considerably from one institution to another. While many programs require foundational coursework in biology, chemistry, anatomy and physiology, microbiology, and statistics, the specific courses, credit hour requirements, laboratory expectations, and acceptable course formats often differ.

Some programs require additional coursework such as genetics, biochemistry, nutrition, medical terminology, psychology, developmental psychology, or sociology. Others may specify minimum grades, require prerequisites to be completed within a certain number of years before matriculation, or limit the acceptance of Advanced Placement (AP), online, or community

college coursework. Programs may also differ in whether they accept repeated courses or how they evaluate courses taken on a pass/fail basis.

Because prerequisite requirements are highly program-specific, **it is essential to research the admission requirements for each PA program you are considering before planning your coursework.** While the table below highlights common prerequisite courses required by many accredited PA programs, it should not be considered a universal list. Always verify current admissions requirements directly with each program, as prerequisites and admissions policies may change from year to year.

Subject	Typical Villanova Coursework	Note
Biology	- BIO 2105 & BIO 2106	2 Semesters w/ Labs Some schools may require or strongly prefer additional biology coursework.
Human Anatomy & Physiology	- BIO 1205 & BIO 1206 OR - BIO 3055 & BIO 3085	2 Semesters w/ Labs Required by many PA programs.
General Chemistry	- CHM 1151 & CHM 1103 AND - CHM 1152 & CHM 1104	2 Semesters w/ Labs Required by many PA programs.
Microbiology	- BIO 3595	1 Semester w/ Lab Frequently required.
English / Writing	- ACS 1000 - ACS 1001 - ENG 1975	2 Semesters Most PA schools require one year of English or writing-intensive coursework. ACS 1000/1001 may satisfy these requirements at some institutions, and CLAS students also complete ENG 1975 as part of their degree requirements. Students outside CLAS may need additional English or writing-intensive coursework to meet the expectations of a broader range of PA schools. Work with your Faculty Advisor to identify appropriate coursework within your academic program and consult

		HPA regarding PA school requirements. Students should verify individual school policies.
Psychology / Social Sciences	- PSY 3200 (Human Development) and/or other psychology or sociology coursework	2 Semesters Many PA programs require psychology and/or human development. Requirements vary considerably by program.
Statistics	- STAT 1230 - STAT 1250 - STAT 1313 - CSC 2300 - PSY 2000	1 Semester May be a STAT course or a course within an alternate discipline such as psychology (PSY 2000). Course selection should be coordinated with the student's Faculty Advisor, as not all statistics courses satisfy requirements for every Villanova major. STAT 1230 and STAT 1250, for example, typically do not fulfill statistics requirements for CLAS STEM programs. PSY 2000 may also have limited availability for students outside the Psychology major.
Organic Chemistry / Biochemistry****	- CHM 2211 & CHM 2201 - CHM 4611 OR - CHM 4621	Varies by Program**** Some PA programs require organic chemistry, biochemistry, or both, while others do not require either, or only require Organic Chemistry I with lab. Students should verify individual program requirements. Organic chemistry I & II are prerequisites for biochemistry at Villanova.

PA programs vary widely in their prerequisite coursework, admissions policies, and application requirements. In addition to required courses, programs may specify minimum grades, prerequisite GPA requirements, expiration dates for completed coursework, or expectations regarding direct patient care experience. Some programs also require or recommend courses such as Nutrition, Medical Terminology, Genetics, and/or Organic Chemistry II. **It is your responsibility to review the admissions requirements for each program before applying, as these requirements may change from year to year.**

Advanced Placement (AP) Credit

Policies regarding Advanced Placement (AP) credit vary considerably among PA programs. While some programs accept AP credit to satisfy prerequisite coursework, others require applicants to complete college-level coursework in the same discipline or do not accept AP credit at all. If you enter Villanova with AP credit, work with your Faculty Advisor to understand how that credit applies to your Villanova degree requirements and course placement. HPA can help you understand how individual PA programs may treat AP credit when evaluating prerequisite requirements.

Planning Your Coursework

Completing the prerequisite courses is only one part of preparing for PA school. Admissions committees also evaluate the rigor of your coursework, trends in academic performance, and your ability to succeed in upper-level science courses. Work with your Faculty Advisor to develop an appropriate course sequence within your degree program, and consult HPA about how prerequisite timing may affect your PA school application timeline and eligibility for particular programs.

GPA and Academic Performance

Why GPA Matters

Your undergraduate GPA is one of the most important indicators of your academic readiness for PA school. PA education is academically rigorous and fast-paced, requiring students to master a broad foundation of biomedical and clinical sciences while developing the knowledge, critical thinking, and clinical reasoning skills necessary to provide safe, effective patient care. Admissions committees use your academic record as evidence of your preparation for the pace and academic demands of PA education.

While GPA is an important component of your application, it is not evaluated in isolation. PA programs review your academic performance in context, considering factors such as your cumulative GPA, science GPA, performance in prerequisite coursework, the rigor of your coursework, and trends in your academic performance over time. They also recognize that academic achievement is only one part of a competitive application. Direct patient care

experience, healthcare exposure, service, leadership, professionalism, and personal attributes all contribute to a holistic understanding of your preparedness for the PA profession.

What Admissions Committees Consider

Many PA programs establish minimum GPA requirements for consideration, including minimum cumulative, science, and/or prerequisite GPAs. Meeting these minimums allows an application to be considered but does not guarantee admission. Competitive applicants often exceed published minimum requirements, particularly at programs with large applicant pools.

Academic Factor	Why It Matters
Overall GPA	Demonstrates consistent academic achievement across all coursework.
Science GPA	Reflects readiness for the biomedical sciences taught in PA school.
Prerequisite GPA	Demonstrates mastery of the foundational courses required by individual PA programs.
Upper-Level Science Courses	Provides additional evidence of academic preparedness and ability to succeed in rigorous science coursework.
Academic Trends	Demonstrates growth, resilience, and continued academic development over time.

Building a Strong Academic Record

Strong academic preparation develops over time. PA programs look for evidence that you can succeed in rigorous coursework while managing the other responsibilities that are part of your undergraduate experience.

Plan your schedule carefully each semester, striving for an appropriate balance between challenging coursework and the time needed to succeed academically. Avoid overloading yourself with multiple demanding science courses if doing so may negatively impact your performance. Consistently strong grades earned over time are generally more beneficial than taking an unnecessarily heavy course load that compromises your academic success.

Develop effective study habits early in your undergraduate career and take advantage of available academic resources, including faculty office hours, tutoring, supplemental instruction, and study groups. If you begin to struggle in a course, seek assistance as soon as possible rather than waiting until the end of the semester. Addressing academic challenges early not only improves your chances of success but also demonstrates initiative and resilience.

Academic performance is considered alongside patient care experience and the other components of your application. Build a schedule that allows you to perform well academically while maintaining the responsibilities and experiences that are important to your preparation for PA school.

If Your GPA Isn't Where You Want It To Be

Many students experience academic challenges during college, whether due to adjusting to the demands of university coursework, personal circumstances, or simply discovering more effective study strategies over time. A semester or even a year of lower-than-expected grades does not automatically prevent you from becoming a competitive PA school applicant.

Admissions committees evaluate your academic record in context. An upward trend in academic performance, particularly in prerequisite and upper-level science courses, can demonstrate resilience, maturity, and your ability to succeed in a rigorous academic environment. Strong performance later in college may provide evidence that you have developed the knowledge, study habits, and time management skills necessary for success in PA school.

If you are concerned about your academic record, meet with HPA early to discuss how your performance may affect your PA school readiness and application timeline. Your Faculty Advisor can help you make decisions about course selection, sequencing, and degree progress, while HPA can help you consider whether repeating prerequisites, additional coursework, or academic enhancement may be useful from an admissions perspective.

HPA Tip: If you're struggling academically, don't wait until you're ready to apply to seek advice. Meeting with HPA early allows more time to evaluate your academic readiness, application timeline, and options for strengthening your preparation.

Planning Your Timeline

Preparing for PA school is a multi-year process. Starting early gives you time to complete prerequisites, explore the profession, gain patient care experience, and prepare for the application while balancing your other responsibilities.

There is no single timeline for applying to PA school. While some students apply during the summer after their junior year and matriculate immediately after graduation, many successful applicants take one or more gap years to gain additional patient care experience, strengthen their academic record, or further explore the profession. HPA can help you evaluate how your academic preparation, patient care experience, and intended programs may affect your application timeline.

First Year

- Begin prerequisite coursework in biology and chemistry.
- Work with your Faculty Advisor on course selection and sequencing, and meet with HPA to discuss PA school prerequisites, career exploration, patient care experience, and your anticipated application timeline.
- Explore the PA profession through shadowing, informational interviews, and involvement in pre-PA organizations.
- Begin investigating patient care roles and any certifications or training they require (e.g., EMT, CNA, Medical Assistant).
- Develop study habits that support long-term academic success.

Second Year

- Continue completing prerequisite coursework.
- Begin or expand direct patient care experience.
- Continue shadowing physician assistants in a variety of practice settings.
- Expand service, leadership, and extracurricular involvement.
- Meet with HPA to review your academic progress and long-term application plan.

Third Year

- Complete the majority of prerequisite coursework.
- Continue building meaningful patient care experience and seek increasing responsibility when appropriate.
- Research PA programs and review their specific prerequisite and admissions requirements.
- If required by your intended programs, prepare for and take the GRE or other admissions assessments.
- Begin identifying letter of recommendation writers.

- Prepare your CASPA application and, if applying without a gap year, plan to submit it early in the application cycle.

Fourth Year

- Complete any remaining degree or prerequisite requirements.
- Continue gaining patient care experience and strengthening your application.
- Participate in interviews and complete supplemental applications as requested.
- Maintain strong academic performance through graduation.
- Prepare for the transition to PA school or continue building your experiences if you plan to apply during a gap year.

HPA Tip: Many successful PA applicants take one or more gap years, particularly to gain additional patient care experience. Apply when you meet the requirements of your intended programs and your overall preparation is competitive.

Building a Competitive Application

Patient Care Experience (PCE)

Direct patient care experience (PCE) is one of the most important, and often most distinctive, components of a competitive PA school application. Unlike many other health professions, PA programs expect applicants to enter graduate school with meaningful hands-on experience caring for patients. These experiences allow applicants to develop clinical skills, strengthen communication and professionalism, and gain a realistic understanding of the responsibilities and challenges of patient care.

Most PA programs require or strongly recommend direct patient care experience before matriculation. However, the amount and type of experience expected varies considerably among programs. Some programs require only a few hundred hours, while others expect applicants to have accumulated well over 2,000 hours of direct patient care experience. Because requirements differ significantly, it is essential to research the expectations of each program you intend to apply to.

What Counts as Patient Care Experience?

In general, patient care experience involves direct responsibility for providing care to patients rather than simply observing or assisting from a distance. These roles typically require applicants to interact directly with patients while performing clinical tasks or contributing to patient care under appropriate supervision.

Examples of common patient care experience roles include:

- Emergency Medical Technician (EMT)
- Paramedic
- Certified Nursing Assistant (CNA)
- Patient Care Technician (PCT)
- Medical Assistant (MA)
- Registered Nurse (RN)
- Licensed Practical/Vocational Nurse (LPN/LVN)
- Respiratory Therapist
- Athletic Trainer
- Physical Therapist Assistant (PTA)
- Occupational Therapy Assistant (OTA)
- Surgical Technologist
- Phlebotomist (**accepted by some programs*)
- Medical Scribe (**accepted by some programs but often classified differently*)

Keep in mind that there is no universal definition of qualifying patient care experience. A role accepted by one PA program may be classified as healthcare experience—or may not satisfy admissions requirements—at another institution. Always verify how each program defines qualifying experience before relying on a particular position to meet its requirements.

Quality Matters Alongside Quantity

While the number of patient care hours is an important consideration, admissions committees are equally interested in the quality of your experiences. They want to see that you have taken on substantive responsibilities, worked directly with patients, and developed the skills necessary to succeed in a rigorous clinical curriculum.

As you gain experience, seek opportunities to build your clinical knowledge, strengthen your communication skills, demonstrate professionalism, and take on increasing levels of responsibility when appropriate. Experiences that expose you to diverse patient populations, interdisciplinary healthcare teams, and a variety of medical conditions can help broaden your understanding of healthcare and better prepare you for PA school.

Document Your Experiences

Keep detailed records of your patient care experience throughout college. Document your job title, employer, dates of employment, hours worked, supervisor information, and a description of your responsibilities. Maintaining accurate records will make completing your CASPA application significantly easier and help ensure that your experiences are represented accurately.

Patient care experience should help you develop clinical skills, understand the responsibilities of caring for patients, and evaluate whether the PA profession is the right fit for you.

HPA Tip: Start gaining patient care experience as early as possible. Building substantial clinical experience takes time, and waiting until your junior or senior year to begin may limit both the number of hours you can accumulate and the depth of responsibility you are able to develop.

Healthcare Experience

Healthcare experience (HCE) includes experiences that expose applicants to the healthcare environment but do not involve primary responsibility for providing direct patient care. These experiences can help you develop an understanding of healthcare systems, patient interactions, and interdisciplinary teamwork while reinforcing your interest in the PA profession.

Examples of healthcare experience may include:

- Medical Scribe (at some programs)
- Medical Receptionist or Front Desk Staff
- Unit Secretary

- Hospital Volunteer
- Patient Transporter
- Pharmacy Technician
- Laboratory Assistant
- Medical Interpreter
- Healthcare Administration or Office Support
- Other healthcare roles with limited or no direct patient care responsibilities

Like patient care experience, there is no universal definition of healthcare experience. A position considered healthcare experience by one PA program may qualify as direct patient care at another, or may not satisfy admissions requirements at all. It is your responsibility to review each program's admissions policies to determine how your experiences will be classified.

Although healthcare experience is generally not viewed as a substitute for direct patient care experience, it can still strengthen your application by demonstrating a sustained commitment to healthcare and providing valuable exposure to clinical environments. Many applicants gain both patient care and healthcare experience before applying, allowing them to develop a broader understanding of the healthcare system and the important role of physician assistants within it.

If you are unsure how a position will be classified, review the policies of your intended programs and contact the program directly when clarification is needed. HPA can help you identify potential differences among programs, but each program determines how it will classify your experience.

HPA Tip: Before accepting a healthcare position, review the admissions requirements for the PA programs that interest you. A role that provides meaningful clinical exposure may not count toward patient care experience requirements at every program, so planning ahead can help you maximize the value of your experiences.

Shadowing

Shadowing physician assistants is an important way to explore the profession and gain a realistic understanding of the PA's role in patient care. While direct patient care experience demonstrates your ability to work with patients, shadowing allows you to observe the day-to-day responsibilities of practicing PAs, their clinical decision-making, and their collaboration with physicians and other members of the healthcare team.

Many PA programs recommend or require applicants to complete shadowing hours before applying. However, expectations vary considerably. Some programs require documented PA shadowing, while others simply encourage applicants to gain exposure to the profession. Because requirements differ among programs, you should review the admissions policies for each school on your list well in advance of applying.

Whenever possible, seek opportunities to shadow PAs in a variety of specialties and practice settings. Observing PAs in primary care, emergency medicine, surgery, internal medicine, pediatrics, or other specialties can provide a broader understanding of the profession and demonstrate the flexibility that defines PA practice. While exposure to multiple settings can be beneficial, meaningful observation and thoughtful reflection are more important than accumulating hours across numerous specialties.

As you shadow, pay close attention to the PA's role within the healthcare team. Observe how they gather patient histories, perform physical examinations, develop differential diagnoses, educate patients, collaborate with physicians and other healthcare professionals, and balance autonomy with teamwork. Consider how the PA communicates with patients, manages challenging situations, and adapts to the unique demands of different clinical environments.

Use shadowing to learn how PAs practice and to evaluate whether the role fits your interests and career goals. Be prepared to discuss what you observed and how those experiences influenced your decision to pursue the profession.

Community Service

Service is a fundamental component of the physician assistant profession. PAs are committed to improving the health and well-being of individuals and communities, often caring for patients during vulnerable moments in their lives. As a result, PA programs seek applicants who have demonstrated a genuine commitment to serving others through sustained and meaningful community involvement.

Community service does not need to be healthcare-related to be valuable. Volunteering with food banks, homeless shelters, youth mentoring programs, crisis hotlines, Special Olympics, refugee assistance organizations, religious or community organizations, environmental initiatives, or other nonprofit organizations can demonstrate compassion, empathy, cultural humility, and a willingness to contribute to the well-being of others. Healthcare-related service, such as volunteering at free clinics or community health outreach events, can also provide meaningful opportunities to engage with underserved populations.

Admissions committees generally place greater value on consistent, long-term involvement than on brief participation in numerous activities. Rather than attempting to accumulate volunteer hours solely to strengthen your application, seek opportunities that align with your interests and values. Sustained service allows you to build relationships, deepen your understanding of community needs, and demonstrate a genuine commitment to helping others.

As you participate in service activities, reflect on what you are learning about yourself and the communities you serve. Consider how your experiences have influenced your understanding of healthcare disparities, social determinants of health, cultural humility, and the importance of compassionate, patient-centered care. These reflections can strengthen your personal statement, interviews, and overall understanding of the role PAs play in improving access to healthcare.

Leadership

Leadership is an important component of a competitive PA school application because it demonstrates your ability to communicate effectively, collaborate with others, solve problems, and positively influence those around you. Physician assistants serve as leaders every day by coordinating patient care, educating patients and families, collaborating with interdisciplinary healthcare teams, and advocating for the health and well-being of their patients.

Leadership can be developed in many settings and does not require holding a formal title.

Meaningful leadership experiences may include:

- Serving as an officer or committee chair in a student organization
- Holding leadership positions in pre-health or pre-PA clubs
- Serving as a resident assistant (RA) or orientation leader
- Working as a peer mentor, tutor, or teaching assistant
- Captaining an athletic team or leading a club sport
- Supervising or training employees in a healthcare or non-healthcare workplace
- Leading volunteer projects or community service initiatives
- Organizing campus events or fundraising efforts
- Participating in student government
- Serving in military or community leadership roles

Admissions committees are often more interested in how you led than where you served. Effective leaders demonstrate initiative, accountability, integrity, teamwork, adaptability, and the ability to work with individuals from diverse backgrounds. Leadership is not measured by the number of titles you hold, but by the impact you have on your team, organization, workplace, or community.

Sustained involvement in a few activities can provide more opportunity to take initiative, assume responsibility, and contribute to a group over time. Long-term commitment and progressive leadership often demonstrate greater maturity and personal growth than brief involvement in many unrelated activities.

As you reflect on your leadership experiences, consider the challenges you faced, the decisions you made, and the ways in which you supported others or improved a process. These experiences provide valuable examples of the communication, professionalism, collaboration, and problem-solving skills that are essential for success as both a PA student and a future physician assistant.

Research

Research is not a requirement for admission to most PA programs. Unlike some other health professions, PA admissions committees generally place greater emphasis on academic performance, direct patient care experience, service, leadership, and a demonstrated

understanding of the profession. Research can still be valuable if it aligns with your academic interests or career goals.

Participating in research allows students to develop skills that are valuable in both PA school and clinical practice, including critical thinking, scientific inquiry, problem-solving, data analysis, and evidence-based decision-making. Research experiences may involve laboratory science, clinical research, public health, psychology, social sciences, health services research, or quality improvement initiatives.

Research experiences may include:

- Assisting with laboratory or clinical research projects
- Collecting or analyzing research data
- Conducting literature reviews
- Participating in quality improvement or patient safety initiatives
- Presenting research at conferences or symposiums
- Co-authoring abstracts, posters, or publications

Admissions committees are generally less concerned with the topic of your research than with what you learned through the experience. Consider how participating in research strengthened your ability to think critically, collaborate with others, interpret scientific literature, or solve complex problems. These transferable skills are valuable for future healthcare providers who must continually evaluate emerging evidence to provide high-quality patient care.

If research is available to you and aligns with your interests, it can be an enriching experience that complements other aspects of your application. However, you should not pursue research at the expense of building meaningful patient care experience, as direct patient care remains one of the most important components of a competitive PA school application.

Professional Competencies

PA programs evaluate more than academic performance and patient care hours. Applicants should also demonstrate communication, teamwork, professionalism, ethical judgment, critical thinking, and a commitment to patient-centered care.

The four national PA organizations – PAEA, AAPA, ARC-PA, and NCCPA – identify [seven broad competency domains](#) that describe the knowledge, skills, and professional behaviors expected of PAs throughout their careers. While these competencies continue to develop during PA school and clinical practice, applicants can begin building these foundations long before they submit their CASPA application.

Competency	How You Can Begin Developing It
Knowledge for Practice	Build a strong foundation in the biomedical sciences, develop effective study habits, and

	learn to apply scientific knowledge to real-world clinical situations.
Interpersonal & Communication Skills	Communicate respectfully with patients, families, peers, and supervisors through employment, volunteering, leadership, and team-based activities.
Person-Centered Care	Develop empathy, cultural humility, compassion, and respect for patients from diverse backgrounds while prioritizing their values, needs, and preferences.
Interprofessional Collaboration	Learn to work effectively with physicians, nurses, therapists, pharmacists, social workers, and other healthcare professionals during patient care experiences.
Professionalism & Ethics	Demonstrate integrity, accountability, reliability, ethical decision-making, respect, and responsibility in academic, clinical, and professional settings.
Practice-Based Learning & Quality Improvement	Seek feedback, reflect on your experiences, identify opportunities for improvement, and commit to lifelong learning and evidence-based practice.
Society & Population Health	Develop an understanding of public health, health disparities, social determinants of health, disease prevention, and your responsibility to improve the health of individuals and communities.

These qualities develop across your academics, patient care experience, employment, service, research, leadership, and interactions with others. As you prepare to apply, consider both what you have done and what those experiences have taught you.

The Application Process

Building a School List

PA programs differ substantially in prerequisites, patient care requirements, admissions criteria, cost, curriculum, clinical training, and mission. Build your school list around programs whose requirements you meet and whose structure and priorities align with your goals.

As you develop your school list, consider factors such as:

- Minimum and average GPA requirements
- Patient care experience expectations
- Required and recommended prerequisite coursework
- Standardized testing requirements (GRE, Casper, or other assessments)
- Program mission and values
- Geographic location and cost of attendance
- Curriculum structure and clinical rotation opportunities
- Program length and graduation outcomes
- First-time PANCE pass rates
- Accreditation status
- Availability of student support services and advising

It is also important to evaluate your own competitiveness honestly. Compare your academic record, patient care experience, and other qualifications with the admissions profiles of recently admitted students when available. Applying only to highly selective programs may limit your opportunities, while applying to programs where your experiences and qualifications align well can increase your likelihood of receiving interview invitations.

Consider both your likelihood of admission and whether the program's curriculum, clinical opportunities, location, cost, and mission make sense for you.

HPA Tip: Meet with an HPA advisor before finalizing your school list. We can help you evaluate your competitiveness, interpret program-specific admissions requirements, and develop a balanced application strategy based on your academic record, patient care experience, and individual preferences.

Application Components Overview

Each component of the PA school application provides different information about your academic preparation, patient care experience, personal qualities, and readiness for PA education. Programs consider these materials together when reviewing applicants.

Application Component	Purpose
CASPA Application	The centralized application through which applicants submit academic information, experiences, personal information, and supporting materials to participating PA programs.
Official Transcripts	Verify your academic record, prerequisite coursework, and cumulative, science, and prerequisite GPAs, as applicable.
Standardized Admissions Assessments (<i>if required</i>)	Depending on the program, applicants may be required to complete the GRE, PA-CAT, Casper, or another admissions assessment.
Personal Statement	An opportunity to explain your motivation for becoming a physician assistant and reflect on the experiences that have prepared you for the profession.
Experiences Section	Documents your patient care experience, healthcare experience, shadowing, community service, leadership, research, employment, and other meaningful activities that demonstrate your readiness for PA school.
Letters of Recommendation	Provide admissions committees with independent evaluations of your academic ability, clinical readiness, professionalism, interpersonal skills, and potential for success in PA school.
Program-Specific Requirements	Many PA programs require additional essays, prerequisite documentation, Casper or other assessments, or supplemental application materials in addition to the CASPA application.
Interviews	Allow admissions committees to assess your communication skills, professionalism, ethical reasoning, interpersonal abilities, and overall fit for their program.

CASPA

The Centralized Application Service for Physician Assistants (CASPA) is the centralized application system used by most accredited physician assistant programs in the United States. Applicants submit one centralized application through CASPA, which is distributed to the participating PA programs they designate.

The CASPA application provides admissions committees with a comprehensive overview of your academic preparation, healthcare experiences, personal background, and readiness for PA education. Through CASPA, you will report your coursework, enter your patient care and healthcare experiences, document volunteer service, leadership, research, employment, certifications, and achievements, submit your personal statement, request letters of recommendation, and designate the PA programs to which you wish to apply.

Although CASPA standardizes much of the application process, individual PA programs maintain their own admissions requirements. Programs may differ in prerequisite coursework, minimum GPA requirements, patient care experience expectations, standardized testing requirements, supplemental essays, application deadlines, and interview processes. It is your responsibility to review the admissions requirements for every program on your school list before submitting your application.

Most PA programs participate in CASPA, but participation is voluntary. Before beginning the application process, verify that each of your intended programs uses CASPA and carefully review any additional application requirements beyond the centralized application.

Because CASPA requires applicants to enter detailed information about their coursework and experiences, completing the application can take considerably longer than many students anticipate. Begin gathering transcripts, documenting your patient care and volunteer experiences, identifying potential letter writers, and preparing your personal statement well before the application cycle opens. Starting early will allow ample time to review your application for accuracy and avoid unnecessary delays during the verification process.

HPA Tip: Create a spreadsheet or document to track each program's prerequisite courses, patient care experience requirements, application deadlines, supplemental requirements, and standardized testing policies. Although CASPA allows you to submit one primary application, every PA program has its own admissions criteria and timeline.

CASPA Timeline

The CASPA application cycle typically opens each year in late April, with individual PA program deadlines extending from summer through the following spring. Because programs operate on different admissions timelines, applicants should review each program's requirements and deadlines well before the application cycle begins.

The following timeline provides a general framework for preparing a competitive application.

Timeframe	Recommended Activities
12–18 months before applying	Complete prerequisite coursework, continue building patient care experience, gain shadowing experience, participate in service and leadership activities, and begin researching PA programs.
6–12 months before applying	Finalize your school list, identify individuals who will write letters of recommendation, prepare for any required admissions assessments, begin drafting your personal statement, and review each program's prerequisite and admissions requirements.
When CASPA opens (late April)	Create your CASPA account, enter coursework, request official transcripts, request letters of recommendation, document experiences, and complete all required application sections.
May–June	Review your application carefully for accuracy and submit your CASPA application as early as possible. Monitor your application for transcript receipt and verification.
Summer–Spring	Complete supplemental applications or additional program requirements, participate in interviews, update programs with significant new experiences when appropriate, and monitor application status throughout the cycle.

Remember that submitting your application is only the first step. After submission, CASPA reviews your application for verification, comparing your reported coursework with your official transcripts and calculating standardized GPAs. Some programs require your application to reach Verified status by their deadline. Once your application is complete, verification can take up to 10 business days.

Entering Coursework

One of the most time-intensive components of the CASPA application is entering your academic coursework. CASPA requires applicants to report every course taken at every U.S. or Canadian college or university attended, regardless of whether the credits were earned before transferring institutions, through dual enrollment, or as part of a study abroad program sponsored by a U.S. institution. This information is used to calculate standardized GPAs that PA programs use during the admissions review process.

When entering coursework, carefully reference your official transcripts to ensure that course titles, course numbers, credit hours, grades, academic terms, and institutions are entered exactly as they appear. Even small errors can delay the verification process or require corrections during verification.

CASPA calculates several GPA metrics, including cumulative, science, and non-science GPAs. However, individual PA programs may also calculate prerequisite GPAs or evaluate coursework differently based on their own admissions policies. Because GPA calculations and prerequisite requirements vary among programs, it is important to review each school's admissions requirements rather than relying solely on your CASPA-calculated GPAs.

If you complete additional coursework after submitting your application, CASPA allows applicants to update academic information through designated Academic Update periods for participating programs. Not all PA programs accept updated coursework after submission, so be sure to review each program's policies regarding academic updates.

Before submitting your application, carefully review every course entry against your official transcripts. Taking the time to verify your coursework can help prevent delays in verification and ensure that admissions committees receive an accurate representation of your academic record.

HPA Tip: When you are ready to apply, follow CASPA's transcript instructions carefully and enter your coursework exactly as it appears on your official transcripts. Errors or missing materials can delay verification.

Experiences Section

The Experiences section allows you to document your responsibilities, hours, and involvement across patient care, healthcare, employment, service, leadership, research, and other activities.

CASPA allows applicants to report a wide range of experiences, including patient care experience, healthcare experience, shadowing, volunteer service, leadership, research, employment, teaching, extracurricular activities, and other meaningful life experiences. Each entry includes information about the organization, dates of participation, total hours, and a brief description of your responsibilities and accomplishments.

As you complete this section, focus on accurately describing your role and the impact of your experiences. Describe your actual responsibilities, the populations you served, your level of involvement, and relevant skills you developed.

Be sure to maintain accurate records of your activities throughout your undergraduate education, including dates, hours, supervisor information, and responsibilities. Waiting until the application cycle to reconstruct several years of experiences can be challenging and may result in inaccurate reporting.

Before submitting your application, carefully review every experience entry for clarity, consistency, and accuracy. Admissions committees often reference these descriptions during interviews, so you should be prepared to discuss each experience in detail.

HPA Tip: The Experiences section is one of the most important, and often overlooked, parts of the CASPA application. If you would like feedback on how to effectively describe your experiences, schedule an appointment with [John McGranaghan in Villanova's Career Center](#). John specializes in helping students translate their experiences into compelling application entries that clearly communicate their skills, growth, and impact while remaining authentic to their individual journey.

Personal Information & Supporting Documents

In addition to your academic record and experiences, the CASPA application requires applicants to provide personal information and supporting documentation that help PA programs evaluate eligibility and process applications efficiently. Completing these sections accurately and thoroughly can help prevent delays in application review and verification.

Within CASPA, you will provide demographic information, contact information, residency status, citizenship information (when applicable), and educational history. You will also report relevant certifications, licenses, language proficiency, honors and awards, and other information requested by participating PA programs.

Supporting documents are another essential component of your application. Applicants are responsible for ensuring that all official transcripts have been received by CASPA, letters of recommendation have been requested and submitted, and any standardized test scores required by individual programs have been reported according to each school's instructions. Some programs may also request additional documentation, such as proof of certifications, prerequisite completion, or supplemental application materials.

Because individual PA programs establish their own admissions requirements, carefully review each program's website to determine whether additional documentation is required beyond the standard CASPA application. Missing or incomplete materials can delay the review of your application or prevent it from being considered complete.

Before submitting your application, review every section carefully to ensure that all information is accurate, complete, and consistent across your application materials. Small errors or omissions can create unnecessary delays and may leave admissions committees with an incomplete picture of your qualifications.

Program Materials

While CASPA provides a centralized application for most PA programs, each participating program establishes its own admissions requirements through the Program Materials section.

This portion of the application allows programs to collect information beyond the standard CASPA application and is often where applicants encounter school-specific requirements.

Depending on the program, the Program Materials section may include supplemental essay questions, prerequisite coursework designations, requests for additional information about patient care experience, prerequisite completion plans, residency verification, or other admissions requirements. Some programs may also ask applicants to explain academic irregularities, discuss specific experiences, or answer questions related to their mission or values.

Because every PA program structures its Program Materials differently, it is important to review each section carefully rather than assuming the requirements are the same across all schools. Even if you are applying to multiple programs, you should tailor your responses to reflect each program's mission, curriculum, clinical opportunities, and areas of emphasis. Thoughtful, program-specific responses demonstrate genuine interest and help admissions committees understand why you believe their program is a good fit for your goals.

The Program Materials section is also where many programs communicate additional application requirements, such as supplemental fees, prerequisite policies, standardized testing requirements, or post-submission instructions. Carefully review these materials before submitting your application to ensure that all required components have been completed.

Remember that submitting your CASPA application does not necessarily mean your application is complete. Some PA programs will not begin reviewing applications until all required Program Materials and supplemental requirements have been received.

CASPA Verification

After you submit your CASPA application, it enters the verification process. During verification, CASPA compares the coursework you entered with your official transcripts to ensure that your academic record has been reported accurately.

Verification is not immediate. Processing times vary throughout the application cycle and are typically longest during periods of high application volume. If corrections are required or supporting documents have not been received, verification may be delayed further.

CASPA places an application in the verification queue once it is complete. In general, this requires submission and payment, receipt of all required official transcripts, at least two completed evaluations, and approval of Professional Transcript Entry if you used that service.

PA programs use different CASPA deadline requirements. Depending on the program, your application may need to be submitted, complete, or verified by the posted deadline. Review the deadline type for every program on your list and allow sufficient time for transcripts, evaluations, and verification when required.

After verification, continue monitoring your CASPA account and the admissions portals for each PA program. Schools may request supplemental materials, invite you to interview, or ask for additional documentation as they review your application.

Applying Early

Whenever possible, plan to submit your CASPA application early in the admissions cycle. Although application timelines and review processes vary among PA programs, submitting a complete application early provides several important advantages and can help reduce unnecessary stress throughout the admissions process.

Many PA programs use rolling admissions, meaning they begin reviewing verified applications and extending interview invitations as applications become complete rather than waiting until the application deadline. As interview dates fill and seats in the incoming class are offered, applying earlier in the cycle may increase your opportunity to be considered while more interview slots and seats remain available.

However, not all PA programs use rolling admissions. Some programs wait until after their application deadline to begin reviewing applications or evaluate applicants in multiple review rounds. Because admissions timelines differ considerably among programs, it is important to understand each school's review process and application deadlines when developing your application strategy.

Applying early also allows additional time for CASPA verification, supplemental application requirements, transcript processing, and letters of recommendation. Unexpected delays can occur during any application cycle, particularly during periods of high application volume. Submitting early provides a buffer to address these issues before application deadlines arrive.

While applying early is advantageous, do not sacrifice the quality of your application simply to submit sooner. Take the time to carefully proofread your personal statement, review your experience descriptions, confirm that your coursework has been entered accurately, and ensure that your application reflects your strongest qualifications. A polished application submitted in June is generally more competitive than a rushed application submitted in May.

Standardized Tests

Standardized testing requirements vary considerably among PA programs. Some programs require the GRE, while others require the PA-CAT, Casper, or another admissions assessment. Many programs do not require a standardized admissions exam at all.

Review the requirements for every program on your school list before registering for an exam. If testing is required, plan far enough in advance to allow time for preparation, score reporting, and a retake if appropriate.

The sections below provide an overview of the GRE, PA-CAT, and Casper.

The Graduate Record Examination (GRE)

The Graduate Record Examination (GRE) is a standardized exam used by some graduate and professional programs to assess academic skills in verbal reasoning, quantitative reasoning, and analytical writing. Although many PA programs no longer require the GRE, some continue to use GRE scores as part of their admissions process, while others list the exam as recommended or optional. Because requirements vary widely, carefully review the admissions policies for each PA program before deciding whether to take the exam.

The GRE assesses three areas:

Section	Assesses
Verbal Reasoning	Reading comprehension, vocabulary, critical reasoning, and the ability to analyze written material.
Quantitative Reasoning	Mathematical reasoning and problem-solving using arithmetic, algebra, geometry, and basic data analysis.
Analytical Writing	The ability to analyze an issue, organize ideas, and communicate effectively through written argument.

Most students preparing for the GRE devote several weeks or months to studying, depending on their academic background and familiarity with the exam content. Preparation may include reviewing foundational math concepts, practicing reading comprehension and vocabulary, completing full-length practice exams, and becoming familiar with the computer-based testing format.

If you are applying to programs that require the GRE, plan to take the exam early enough to allow adequate time for score reporting and, if necessary, a retake before your earliest application deadline. Taking the exam several months before submitting your CASPA application can reduce unnecessary stress during the application cycle and provide flexibility if you wish to improve your score.

Casper

Casper is an online situational judgment test used by some PA programs to assess how applicants respond to interpersonal and professional scenarios. The test focuses on qualities such as communication, collaboration, empathy, professionalism, and ethical judgment rather than science content.

Casper does not require traditional content review. Applicants should become familiar with the test format, practice responding within the allotted time, and be prepared to explain their reasoning clearly and professionally.

Because only some PA programs require Casper, review the requirements and testing deadlines for each program before registering.

Physician Assistant College Admission Test (PA-CAT)

The [Physician Assistant College Admission Test \(PA-CAT\)](#) is an admissions exam developed specifically for PA programs. Unlike the GRE or Casper, the PA-CAT focuses on academic preparation in prerequisite science subjects commonly encountered before PA school.

The exam contains 240 multiple-choice questions covering nine subject areas: anatomy, physiology, general biology, biochemistry, general and organic chemistry, microbiology, behavioral sciences, genetics, and statistics. The current PA-CAT uses a 200–800 scaled score, and official scores are generally available within six weeks. Scores are valid for two years.

Only some PA programs require or use the PA-CAT, so students should not take the exam unless it is relevant to the programs they are considering. If one or more programs on your school list require the PA-CAT, review the official exam blueprint and preparation resources before selecting a test date.

HPA Tip: As you build your school list, track each program's testing requirements, deadlines, and score-reporting policies. Do not assume that a test required by one PA program will be required by another.

Personal Statement

The personal statement is one of the few components of your PA school application that allows admissions committees to hear your voice. While your transcripts, patient care experiences, and other application materials demonstrate what you have accomplished, the personal statement helps explain why you are pursuing a career as a physician assistant and how your experiences have prepared you for the profession.

A strong personal statement explains why you want to become a PA and reflects on the experiences that shaped that decision. Admissions committees should come away with a clear understanding of why the PA role specifically fits your interests, experiences, and career goals.

Focus on the experiences that most influenced your decision to pursue the PA profession and what you learned from them. Use specific examples to show your understanding of the PA role, your development, and the qualities you would bring to PA school.

A strong personal statement should:

- Clearly explain your motivation for pursuing the physician assistant profession.
- Demonstrate a thoughtful understanding of the PA role and why it aligns with your career goals.
- Reflect meaningfully on experiences that have shaped your decision to become a PA.
- Highlight qualities such as compassion, professionalism, resilience, integrity, communication, and teamwork.
- Show how your academic preparation, patient care experiences, and personal growth have prepared you for PA school.
- Be authentic, well organized, and free of grammatical and spelling errors.

Revise your statement through multiple drafts and seek feedback while making sure the final essay still sounds like you.

Personal Statement Support at Villanova

The Health Professions Advising (HPA) Program strongly encourages students to take advantage of the writing support available through Villanova's Career Center. John McGranaghan, Assistant Director of the Career Center, has extensive experience helping pre-health students develop compelling personal statements and application essays for professional school.

Students are encouraged to work with both HPA and John McGranaghan throughout the writing process. HPA can provide an admissions perspective on whether your essay clearly communicates your motivation for the PA profession and reflects your preparation for PA school. The Career Center can provide feedback on organization, clarity, style, grammar, and overall presentation.

Letters of Recommendation

Letters of recommendation (LORs) provide physician assistant programs with an independent assessment of your academic ability, professionalism, character, and readiness for a career as a PA. Strong letters offer insight into who you are beyond your GPA and list of experiences.

The best letters come from individuals who know you well and can speak to your strengths through specific examples, not simply those with impressive titles.

Who Should Write My Letters?

Unlike some other health professions, letter requirements vary considerably among PA programs. Some programs require or strongly recommend a letter from a practicing physician assistant, while others prefer letters from science faculty, healthcare supervisors, or employers. Because expectations differ from school to school, it is essential to review the admissions requirements for every PA program on your list before requesting letters.

Potential letter writers may include:

- A practicing physician assistant who has supervised or worked closely with you
- A healthcare supervisor from your patient care experience or clinical employment
- Science faculty members who can speak to your academic preparation
- Research mentors or principal investigators
- Employment supervisors
- Faculty advisors or mentors
- Volunteer or community service supervisors

Whenever possible, request letters well in advance of your intended application submission date. Give your recommenders ample time to write thoughtful letters, and provide them with materials that will help them write a stronger recommendation, such as your résumé, personal statement draft, transcript, and a summary of your experiences and career goals.

HPA Tip: Villanova students also have the option of participating in the Health Professions Advising (HPA) Letter Packet process, which is described later in this section. This service allows HPA to compile your individual letters of recommendation into a single packet for submission through CASPA. **The packet counts as one CASPA evaluation, so students may need additional individual evaluations depending on the requirements of their intended programs.**

What Makes a Strong Letter?

Effective letters use specific examples to describe qualities relevant to your preparation for PA school.

Strong letters often address your:

- Academic ability
- Critical thinking and problem-solving skills
- Communication and interpersonal skills
- Professionalism and ethical conduct
- Reliability, responsibility, and work ethic
- Leadership and initiative
- Ability to work as part of a team
- Compassion, empathy, and patient-centered approach
- Clinical aptitude and readiness for the rigor of PA education

Building Relationships with Potential Recommenders

Identify potential recommenders well before you apply and give them opportunities to know your academic, clinical, or professional work.

Consider ways to build these relationships by:

- Attending office hours and engaging with faculty outside of class
- Participating actively in lectures and laboratory courses
- Seeking research opportunities with faculty mentors
- Taking on leadership roles within student organizations
- Serving as a teaching assistant, peer tutor, or mentor
- Building strong relationships with supervisors during patient care employment or volunteer experiences
- Shadowing physician assistants and seeking mentorship when appropriate
- Staying in touch with faculty and supervisors after completing a course or position
- Asking thoughtful questions and demonstrating a genuine interest in learning and professional development

Remember that strong recommendation letters come from individuals who have observed your growth, character, and abilities over time. By consistently demonstrating professionalism, initiative, curiosity, and reliability, you make it easier for recommenders to write detailed, personalized letters that highlight your readiness for PA school and the physician assistant profession.

When Should I Ask?

Plan to request letters at least 2–3 months before you need them, and ideally before the end of the semester if asking a faculty member.

Giving recommenders plenty of time allows them to write thoughtful, detailed letters.

What Should I Provide to My Recommenders?

To help your recommender write a strong letter, consider providing:

- Current resume or CV
- Unofficial transcript
- Personal statement draft (if available)
- Brief statement describing why you are pursuing a career as a PA
- List of schools (optional)
- Summary of experiences since taking their course or working with them
- Submission instructions and deadlines

Providing this information allows recommenders to write more personalized and detailed letters.

Waiving Your Right to View Letters

Applicants are generally encouraged to waive their right to view recommendation letters.

Physician assistant programs often place greater confidence in confidential letters because they are more likely to represent an honest assessment.

Villanova Health Professions Advising Letter Packet Process

Villanova HPA offers an optional letter packet service for students applying to PA school. HPA collects individual letters of recommendation from your recommenders and compiles them into a single packet for submission through CASPA. **CASPA counts the entire HPA letter packet as one evaluation, regardless of the number of individual letters included in the packet.**

Because PA programs establish their own letter requirements, students using the HPA letter packet may also need to request additional individual evaluations through CASPA to satisfy the requirements of their intended programs. Always review each program's evaluation requirements carefully before determining who should submit letters on your behalf.

HPA Letter Packet Interest Form and Application

Step 1: Submit the HPA Letter Packet Interest Form

- The HPA Letter Packet Interest Form will be available in mid-October for students considering applying in the upcoming cycle. The form will be available through [HPA Brightspace](#) and [HPA Career Connections](#).
- For students applying in the **2027–2028 cycle, the Interest Form is due Friday, January 15, 2027.**
- Students who do not submit the Interest Form by the January 15 deadline will not be eligible to participate in the HPA letter packet process for the 2027–2028 cycle.

Step 2: Complete the HPA Letter Packet Slate Application

- The HPA Letter Packet Slate Application for the **2027–2028 cycle** will open in Slate on **Tuesday, January 19, 2027**. The application link will be emailed to students who submitted the Interest Form by the deadline.
- Instructions and required forms will be provided within the Slate application.

Step 3: Upload Application Preparation Materials

- Students must upload the following materials to Slate by **Friday, April 2, 2027**:
 - Unofficial transcripts from *all* attended institutions, including Villanova University, community colleges, etc.
 - Polished draft of personal statement
 - Resume/CV
 - Pre-Meeting Questionnaire
- After uploading these materials, students are required to meet with an HPA advisor for an application preparation meeting. **Completion of this meeting is required to receive an HPA letter packet.**

Step 4: Complete Letter Packet Requirements

- HPA will collect individual letters of recommendation directly from recommenders for inclusion in the HPA letter packet. Applicants participating in the HPA process must provide a **minimum of three and maximum of five letters of recommendation** for the packet. **When submitted through CASPA, the completed HPA packet counts as one evaluation.** Students are responsible for determining whether additional individual evaluations must be submitted separately through CASPA to meet the requirements of their intended PA programs.
- Before HPA can submit a letter packet, the following must also be completed in Slate:
 - o Code Form
 - o Authorization of Release
 - o Names and contact information of recommenders
 - o All required letters of recommendation and evaluations received by HPA
- Required HPA application preparation meeting completed

Step 5: Packet Compilation and Submission

- Letter packet compilation begins in May. HPA will submit the completed packet through CASPA once all requirements have been completed.
- **The Slate application and all remaining letter packet requirements must be completed no later than September 1, 2027.** HPA will not process letter packets for students who have not completed all requirements by this deadline.

2027 HPA Letter Packet Process Important Dates & Deadlines	
Mid-October 2026	HPA Letter Packet Interest Form Available on Brightspace and Career Connections
January 15, 2027	HPA Letter Packet Interest Form Due
January 19, 2027	HPA Letter Packet Slate Application Available
April 2, 2027	Application preparation materials listed in Step 3 due in Slate
March-May 2027	Meet with HPA advisor for application prep meeting
September 1, 2027	Final Letter Packet Completion Deadline

Interviews

Receiving an interview invitation is a significant milestone in the PA school admissions process. It indicates that the admissions committee believes you have the academic preparation, experiences, and potential to succeed in their program. The interview provides an opportunity for programs to learn more about you beyond your written application and evaluate qualities that cannot be fully assessed through transcripts, personal statements, or letters of recommendation.

PA school interviews are designed to assess your communication skills, professionalism, interpersonal abilities, ethical reasoning, maturity, and motivation for pursuing the physician assistant profession. Interviewers are interested not only in your experiences but also in your ability to reflect on those experiences, articulate your career goals, and demonstrate the qualities necessary to provide compassionate, patient-centered care.

Interview formats vary among programs and may include:

- Traditional one-on-one interviews
- Panel interviews
- Multiple Mini Interviews (MMIs)
- Group interviews
- Virtual interviews
- In-person interview days that include tours, presentations, and opportunities to interact with faculty, students, and admissions staff

Regardless of the format, successful interviews require thoughtful preparation. Review your application thoroughly, including your personal statement and experience descriptions, as interviewers frequently ask applicants to expand upon information included in their CASPA application. Be prepared to discuss your patient care experiences, leadership roles, service activities, ethical dilemmas, challenges you have overcome, and your understanding of the physician assistant profession.

Interview preparation should also include researching each program before your interview. Familiarize yourself with the program's mission, curriculum, clinical training opportunities, areas of emphasis, and unique features. Demonstrating a genuine understanding of why a program aligns with your goals shows thoughtful preparation and sincere interest.

Throughout the interview process, remember that professionalism extends beyond the formal interview itself. Every interaction with admissions staff, faculty, current students, and other applicants contributes to the impression you leave. Arrive prepared, dress professionally, communicate respectfully, and demonstrate the maturity, integrity, and interpersonal skills expected of future healthcare professionals.

HPA Tip: The Villanova Career Center offers mock interviews to help students prepare for PA school interviews. Practicing your responses, receiving constructive feedback, and becoming comfortable discussing your experiences can improve both your confidence and your interview performance.

Gap Years & Academic Enhancement

Gap Years

Many PA applicants take one or more gap years to gain additional patient care experience, complete prerequisites, strengthen their academic preparation, or apply when they are better prepared. PA programs are accustomed to applicants following different timelines.

Students choose to take gap years for many reasons. Some wish to accumulate additional direct patient care experience or shadow physician assistants, while others pursue research, community service, employment, or leadership opportunities that strengthen their understanding of healthcare and enhance their readiness for PA school. Some students use this time to complete prerequisite coursework, prepare for or retake required admissions assessments, if applicable, or improve their academic record, while others appreciate the opportunity to enter graduate school with greater confidence, maturity, and clinical experience.

Use your gap year to address the areas of your preparation that matter most for your intended programs, whether that means gaining patient care experience, completing coursework, strengthening your academic record, or pursuing other professional goals.

Making the Most of a Gap Year

Choose gap-year activities based on the areas of your preparation you need to strengthen and the requirements of your intended programs.

Examples include:

- Working in a direct patient care role, such as an EMT, medical assistant, certified nursing assistant (CNA), patient care technician (PCT), or another hands-on clinical position
- Expanding your patient care experience by taking on greater responsibility or working with diverse patient populations
- Shadowing physician assistants in a variety of specialties and practice settings
- Participating in community service or public health initiatives
- Conducting research or quality improvement projects
- Completing prerequisite coursework or pursuing academic enhancement, if appropriate
- Preparing for or retaking the GRE, if required by your selected programs
- Gaining leadership experience through employment, student organizations, or volunteer activities
- Saving money to help offset the costs of the application process and PA school

Academic Enhancement

For some students, additional academic preparation after graduation may be beneficial before applying to PA school. Academic enhancement can strengthen an application by demonstrating

improved academic performance, reinforcing foundational science knowledge, or completing prerequisite coursework. It is not necessary—or appropriate—for every applicant. Whether academic enhancement is recommended depends on your individual academic record, prerequisite GPA, and the expectations of the PA programs to which you plan to apply.

Two common pathways for academic enhancement are post-baccalaureate (post-bacc) programs and Specialized Master's Programs (SMPs).

Program Type	Purpose
Post-Baccalaureate Program	Designed for students who need to complete prerequisite coursework, improve their undergraduate GPA, or demonstrate stronger academic performance through additional undergraduate-level science courses.
Specialized Master's Program (SMP)	Graduate-level programs that provide advanced biomedical science coursework similar to the first year of many health professions programs. These programs are generally intended for applicants who have completed the prerequisites but need to demonstrate their ability to succeed in a rigorous graduate-level curriculum.

Academic enhancement is only one way to strengthen an application. Depending on your individual circumstances, gaining additional direct patient care experience, improving prerequisite grades, expanding your shadowing or community service experiences, strengthening your leadership experiences, or delaying your application to continue developing professionally may be more beneficial than pursuing additional coursework.

Post-baccalaureate programs and SMPs require a significant investment of time and money. Additional coursework is most useful when it addresses a specific academic need; enrolling in a program does not automatically make an applicant more competitive.

HPA Tip: Before pursuing a post-baccalaureate program, SMP, or another form of academic enhancement, meet with your Health Professions Advisor. Together, you can evaluate your academic record, patient care experience, and career goals to determine whether academic enhancement, or another strategy, is the most effective way to strengthen your application.

Frequently Asked Questions

Exploring the Physician Assistant Profession FAQ

Do I have to know I want to be a PA before starting college?

No. Many successful physician assistant applicants discover an interest in the profession during college after exploring healthcare careers through coursework, shadowing, volunteer experiences, or conversations with practicing PAs. The purpose of career exploration is to help you make an informed decision before committing to the application process.

How can I determine if the PA profession is the right fit for me?

The best way to explore the profession is through direct exposure. Shadow physician assistants in different practice settings, gain hands-on patient care experience, speak with practicing PAs, and reflect on what you learn. These experiences will help you better understand the responsibilities, challenges, and rewards of the profession while allowing you to determine whether a career as a PA aligns with your interests, values, and goals.

Can physician assistants change specialties during their careers?

Yes. One of the defining characteristics of the PA profession is its flexibility. Because PAs are educated as medical generalists, many transition between specialties throughout their careers without completing an entirely new educational program. Additional training and onboarding are often provided by employers when changing specialties.

Do I need patient care experience before applying to PA school?

Most PA programs expect applicants to have direct patient care experience before matriculation, although specific requirements vary by program. Many successful applicants accumulate hundreds, or even thousands, of hours working in roles such as medical assistant, EMT, certified nursing assistant (CNA), patient care technician (PCT), or other positions that involve direct responsibility for patient care. Always review each program's admissions requirements, as expectations differ.

Can I apply to PA school immediately after graduating from college?

Yes. Some students apply during their junior or senior year of college and matriculate shortly after graduation. However, many applicants choose to take one or more gap years to gain additional patient care experience, strengthen their academic record, or further develop professionally before applying. There is no single "correct" timeline—the best time to apply is when your application reflects your strongest preparation for PA school.

Academic Preparation FAQ

Can I major in something other than biology?

Yes. PA programs accept applicants from a wide variety of academic majors, provided they complete the required prerequisite coursework. Choose a major that interests you, aligns with your strengths, and allows you to perform well academically.

Will AP credit satisfy PA school prerequisites?

It depends on the PA program. Some programs accept Advanced Placement (AP) credit, while others require applicants to complete college-level coursework in the same subject. Always review the admissions requirements for each program to which you plan to apply.

What if I earn a C in a prerequisite course?

A single C does not automatically prevent you from being admitted to PA school, but repeated low grades or poor performance in prerequisite science courses may make you less competitive. Some PA programs also require a minimum grade in prerequisite courses. If you are concerned about your academic record, meet with HPA to discuss strategies for strengthening your application before applying.

Do PA programs look at my science GPA separately from my overall GPA?

Yes. Through CASPA, PA programs receive your cumulative GPA as well as several standardized GPA calculations, including your science GPA. Many programs also evaluate your prerequisite GPA separately. Admissions committees consider these metrics alongside course rigor, academic trends, patient care experience, and other components of your application.

Should I take additional upper-level science courses beyond the prerequisites?

It depends. PA programs vary substantially in both required and recommended coursework, so additional science courses may be useful for some students but unnecessary for others. Work with your Faculty Advisor to determine which courses fit your academic interests, degree requirements, and course sequence, and consult HPA about PA program requirements and admissions considerations.

Building a Competitive Application FAQ

How much patient care experience (PCE) do I need?

There is no universal patient care experience requirement. Some PA programs require a minimum number of hours, while others simply recommend or strongly prefer substantial direct patient care experience. Because expectations vary widely, always review the admissions requirements for each program on your school list. Focus on gaining enough experience to develop direct patient-care skills and understand the responsibilities of caring for patients, not simply reaching a particular number of hours.

Do I need research to be competitive?

Research is not required for admission to most PA programs, but it can strengthen your application by demonstrating critical thinking, problem-solving, and intellectual curiosity. If you choose to participate in research, focus on understanding the research process and your role in the work. For most applicants, direct patient care experience remains a higher priority than research.

Can I count paid employment as experience?

Absolutely. Many applicants gain their patient care experience through paid employment. Positions such as medical assistant, EMT, certified nursing assistant (CNA), patient care technician (PCT), respiratory therapist, paramedic, and other hands-on clinical roles are common ways to build direct patient care experience. However, how individual positions are classified varies by PA program, so always review each program's admissions requirements.

Do all of my experiences need to be healthcare-related?

No. While meaningful patient care experience and exposure to the PA profession are essential, admissions committees also value experiences that demonstrate service, leadership, teamwork, communication, resilience, and personal growth. A well-rounded application reflects not only your preparation for a career in healthcare but also your development as a compassionate, engaged, and service-oriented individual.

Is shadowing a physician assistant required?

It depends on the program. Some PA programs require or strongly recommend shadowing a practicing physician assistant, while others simply encourage applicants to gain exposure to the profession. Even when shadowing is not required, it is an excellent way to better understand the PA role, observe collaborative patient care, and confirm that the profession aligns with your career goals.

CASPA and Application Process FAQ

When should I submit my CASPA application?

Submit your application as early as possible once it is complete and you are confident it reflects your strongest work. Many PA programs use rolling admissions, meaning applications are reviewed as they become complete rather than after the application deadline. Early submission may increase your opportunity to receive an interview invitation while more interview dates and seats remain available. However, because not all PA programs use rolling admissions, be sure to understand each school's admissions timeline.

Can I submit my application before taking the GRE (if applicable)?

Yes, but this should be part of a larger application strategy if the program(s) you are applying to require the GRE. Many programs will not consider your application complete until official GRE scores have been received. If possible, plan to complete the GRE before or shortly after submitting your CASPA application to avoid unnecessary delays. Students are strongly encouraged to discuss their testing timeline and application strategy with HPA before applying.

Should I retake the GRE (if applicable)?

A GRE retake should be a strategic decision rather than an automatic response to a disappointing score. Consider your overall application, the PA programs to which you plan to apply, and whether additional preparation is likely to result in meaningful improvement. For many applicants, strengthening patient care experience or other aspects of the application may have a greater impact than a modest increase in GRE scores. Meet with HPA to discuss your individual situation before scheduling another attempt.

How many PA programs should I apply to?

There is no ideal number that fits every applicant. Your school list should include programs that align with your academic metrics, patient care experience, career goals, geographic preferences, and financial considerations. HPA can help you develop a balanced and realistic school list based on your individual profile.

Can I update my CASPA application after I submit it?

Some information, such as new experiences, additional program designations, updated GRE scores, and certain contact information, can be added after submission. However, many sections – including your personal statement and previously entered coursework – cannot be edited once your application has been submitted. Some PA programs also accept academic updates or application updates, while others do not. Review each program's policies carefully.

How do I choose which PA programs to apply to?

Consider each program's prerequisite requirements, patient care experience expectations, admissions requirements, mission, curriculum, clinical rotation opportunities, location, tuition, accreditation status, and first-time PANCE pass rates. Apply to programs where your academic

record, experiences, and career goals are a strong fit rather than selecting schools based solely on reputation. Students are encouraged to meet with HPA to develop a thoughtful school list.

What makes a strong personal statement?

A strong personal statement clearly explains why you want to become a PA and reflects on the experiences that shaped that decision. Use specific examples rather than repeating information already listed elsewhere in your application.

Can I reuse letters of recommendation from a previous application cycle?

Yes. If you are going through the Villanova HPA letter packet process during your reapplication, we can submit your old letters of recommendation on your behalf. However, *one new letter of recommendation is required* for reapplicants.

What if one of my recommenders submits their letter late?

You may submit your CASPA application before all letters of recommendation have been received. However, many PA programs will not review your application until all required letters have been submitted. Request letters well in advance of your intended submission date and monitor their status throughout the application cycle.

Do I need to complete supplemental applications?

Possibly. While some PA programs only require the standard CASPA application, others require supplemental essays, additional forms, prerequisite documentation, supplemental fees, Casper, or other program-specific requirements. Monitor your email and CASPA account regularly, and complete any additional requirements promptly, as many programs will not review your application until all required materials have been received.

Gap Years & Academic Enhancement FAQ

Will taking a gap year hurt my chances of admission?

No. Many successful applicants take one or more gap years before PA school to gain additional patient care experience, strengthen their application, or ensure they are fully prepared for the demands of PA education. What matters most is how you use that time and whether it demonstrates continued personal, academic, and professional growth.

Should I complete a post-baccalaureate program or an SMP?

It depends on your individual academic record and application goals. Post-baccalaureate programs are generally intended to improve undergraduate academic performance or complete prerequisite coursework, while Specialized Master's Programs (SMPs) are designed for applicants who need to demonstrate success in rigorous graduate-level biomedical science coursework. Meet with HPA before pursuing either option to determine which, if any, is appropriate for your situation.

What should I do during a gap year?

A meaningful gap year should be intentional and focused on continued growth. Common activities include gaining additional direct patient care experience, expanding shadowing experiences, participating in community service, conducting research, completing prerequisite coursework, preparing for or retaking the GRE (if required), or strengthening your academic record. Choose experiences that align with your goals and help prepare you for PA school.

How do I know if academic enhancement is right for me?

Academic enhancement may be appropriate if your academic record does not accurately reflect your ability to succeed in PA school. Before enrolling in additional coursework or graduate programs, meet with HPA to review your academic performance, patient care experience, and overall competitiveness. Together, you can determine whether academic enhancement, or another strategy, is the most effective way to strengthen your application.

Should I focus on improving my GPA or gaining more patient care experience?

It depends on the strengths and weaknesses of your application. For some applicants, additional science coursework or academic enhancement may significantly improve their competitiveness. For others, gaining more direct patient care experience may have a greater impact. Because every applicant's situation is unique, discuss your academic record, clinical experiences, and school list with HPA before deciding how to strengthen your application.

In Conclusion

Preparing for PA school requires strong academic preparation, substantial patient care experience, an informed understanding of the profession, and careful attention to individual program requirements.

Successful PA applicants follow many different academic and application timelines. Focus on meeting the requirements of your intended programs and developing the academic preparation, patient care experience, and professional skills needed for PA education.

This handbook is intended to provide a foundation for that journey, but it is not a substitute for individualized advising. Admissions requirements evolve, application processes change, and every student's circumstances are different. Throughout your time at Villanova, and even after graduation, the Health Professions Advising (HPA) Program is here to support you through every stage of the process. Whether you are exploring the PA profession for the first time, planning for PA school prerequisites, building patient care experience, preparing your CASPA application, selecting programs, or considering a gap year, we encourage you to seek guidance early and often.

We are excited to support you as you pursue your goals and look forward to working with you throughout your journey to becoming a physician assistant.

Best wishes for continued success,

The Villanova University Health Professions Advising Program